Michael's Testimony

How YHWH took a man out of gangs, jail, and addiction, and made him a husband and a father.

Michael Ben Yah. All Scripture from the World English Bible, divine name rendered YHWH, Elohim, and Adonai.

WHERE I STARTED

I want to step back and explain how all of this started.

I grew up with a wonderful mother who took me to church and taught me the things of YHWH. But even with that foundation, I carried pain and unforgiveness in my heart because I grew up in a divorced and broken home.

As a teenager I drifted into gangs and criminal activity. The trauma I went through did not stay trauma. It turned into bitterness and unforgiveness, and that is what opened the doors. Unforgiveness gives the enemy legal ground in your life, and once he has ground he does not sit still with it. *(Ephesians 4:26-27, Hebrews 12:15)*

Those open doors led me into bad relationships, addictions, and destructive patterns. Deep down I always wanted to do what was right. I just did not know that demons were influencing me, and I would not know it until the day I was delivered.

THE ROAD I WAS ON

I was using drugs, drinking heavily, fornicating, and going in and out of jail. That road was leading straight to death.

Even then, YHWH had His hand on me. He guided me into the Army, and the Army gave me the first sense of direction I ever had that was not street life. It taught me discipline. It taught me leadership. It showed me there was a better path to live. And that was where I first started to know that I was lost and that I needed Yahshua.

I started a family. That marriage ended in divorce in 2009, from immaturity on my part and unfaithfulness on hers, and their mother took the children.

My twenties and thirties were full of mistakes. I struggled to stay away from drugs and alcohol, and I turned back to them every time the pain got too heavy. My mom had planted faith in me, but I did not truly believe there was a spiritual realm. Still, I started going to church regularly, and I kept hearing the same three words over and over: demons, deliverance, unforgiveness.

THE ENCOUNTER

The weekend of December 22, 2011, I attended an Encounter at Tarpley, a three day deliverance event hosted by one of the churches I was attending. I was twenty nine years old.

The first two days were prayer, reflection, and writing down traumas and hidden hurts so we could forgive the people who wounded us. I asked YHWH to reveal the unforgiveness buried deep inside my heart, and He did. Some of what He brought up were things I did not even remember. That is where the real healing started. I wrote letters and I forgave people I had been holding in my heart for years. *(Matthew 18:34-35)*

The whole time there was praise and worship going up, inviting His presence into the atmosphere. Somewhere in that process I began to understand that I needed deliverance. Demons had a hold on my life and they were influencing my decisions and my behavior.

The third day was the deliverance session. By then Yah had already shown me that the root of all of it was unforgiveness, and that I had to release it if I wanted to be healed and walk the new path with Him that I had always wanted deep down.

The pastor was leading a mass deliverance. At some point he must have seen that I had a demon, because he and the team came straight over, surrounded me, and started praying. When he commanded the demon to come out, I was told to breathe out.

When I did, I felt something leave my body. It is hard to explain to somebody who has never been through it. I immediately felt lighter, like an oppressive force I had been carrying my whole life had just been lifted off of me.

Right there I declared Yahshua as my Lord and Savior and invited the Holy Spirit to dwell in me. That night I felt more peace than I had ever felt. *(John 8:36, 2 Corinthians 5:17)*

The next morning I woke up with joy, and with the feeling that I had something wonderful to share with the world.

DELIVERED, BUT NOT YET REFINED

Five weeks later, at the end of January 2012, I got married again.

I tell you that on purpose, because it shows you exactly where I was. I had been set free but I had not been refined. I was still reaching for a person instead of letting Yah finish what He had started in me.

I started a family again, and this time I was getting closer to Yahshua. I was reading my Bible. I was starting to reject the false teachings in the churches I was sitting in. And the closer I got to Him, the more tension it created at home, because I was learning that she did not love Yahshua the way I did.

She was unfaithful in 2015. I tried to forgive it and make the marriage work for the sake of our children and to keep the family together. We separated in August 2016 and eventually divorced.

I had been delivered, but I was still tied to someone who had not been. That soul tie kept me spiritually attached even while I was praying, breaking generational curses, and trying to walk a set apart life. No matter how hard I tried to move forward, I was sabotaged at every turn, and the toxicity created more trauma, more bitterness, and more to forgive. *(1 Corinthians 6:16)*

LEARNING WHAT I WAS LIVING IN

I did not have a name for what I was living in. I only knew I was confused, and that nothing I did ever fixed anything.

So I started talking to people about my situation. They recognized the signs long before I did. That sent me to studying it, and the more I read, the more I saw my own house on the page. Yah led me through every bit of that. He used other people to open my eyes because I could not see it from the inside.

Most of that season was just me and Yahshua. Praying. Reading. Learning. And He taught me things I never would have chosen to learn.

He taught me how to be silent. That was the hardest one. He taught me I did not have to defend my position every single time it was attacked. Yahshua stood in front of Pilate and would not answer the charges. When He was reviled, He did not revile back. I had spent years trying to explain myself to someone who was never listening. *(Matthew 27:12-14, 1 Peter 2:23)*

He taught me boundaries. What they are, why they matter, and that putting one up is not unloving. *(Proverbs 4:23)*

And He showed me what the love bombing actually was. It was not love coming back around. It was manipulation to pull me back under control, every time.

The worst of it was the children being used as a weapon against me. That hurt in a place nothing else reaches.

WHAT FORGIVENESS ACTUALLY IS

I had to learn what forgiveness is and what it is not.

Forgiveness was for me. It was how I healed. It was how I put down the bitterness I had been dragging since I was a kid. And it was hard. It was very hard.

But forgiving her never excused what she did, and it was never a reason to stand there and let the abuse keep going. Those are two different things and the enemy loves it when people confuse them. You can release someone completely and still never hand them access to you again.

Forgiving made me stronger. Staying would have made me sick.

WHAT I SAW LOOKING BACK

The day I was delivered, on the drive home, she told me she was jealous of me.

I did not think much of it then. There were other things after that I did not think much of either. But I have gone back over that season many times since, and I believe the same demon that had been tormenting me went looking for a house and found one. Scripture says an unclean spirit driven out goes through dry places looking for somewhere to go. *(Matthew 12:43-45)*

I am not guessing at this from a distance. I lived in the middle of it for years, and the attacks have never stopped, not even to this day.

That is why the boundaries stay up. Not because I am bitter. Because the enemy reattaches through any door you leave cracked.

MY CHILDREN

The hardest part of this story is not the drugs or the jail. It is my children.

I am in contact with my oldest from the first marriage. The door is wide open for the other two and always will be, but they have not reached out yet, and I am not going to force it.

After the second marriage ended I tried my best to stay in my two children's lives from that marriage. The manipulation and the hatred aimed at me and at Rebekah made that impossible, and eventually I had to set a boundary and stop communicating with their mother. That boundary cost me contact with them. I told them so myself on the last phone call, almost two years ago now.

I have kept the same phone number since. Same address. Everything about me is public on purpose. When they are old enough to come looking, there will be nothing to find but an open door and a father who is easy to locate.

I pay my child support. I pray for them every single day. I miss them more than I know how to write down.

This is what I mean when I say boundaries cost something. Yah taught me to protect the peace He gave me, and I obeyed Him, and obedience was expensive. I would still obey Him. But I will not pretend it was free. *(Isaiah 55:11)*

THE REFINING YEARS

From the separation in August 2016 to the day I married Rebekah was seven years. Those years belonged to Yah.

That was the season He spent refining me. He drew me closer to Him than I had ever been, and He started teaching me His ways and His instructions. He brought me into the Sabbath. He brought me into the feast days. Every layer He pulled off me made the next thing clearer. *(1 Peter 1:6-7, Malachi 3:3)*

And I was not learning it alone. I had my two children with me for part of that road, and everything Yah was teaching me I turned around and taught them. *(Proverbs 22:6)*

The week before Passover 2021, I told Yahshua I was all in. No more one foot in and one foot out. I committed my life to His Torah, His instructions, all of it.

I spent that Passover with my children and walked them into this part of the faith for the first time. I do not know what they will hold onto. But they saw their father change in front of them, and I pray that the couple of years they had of that stays in them until the day it matters.

HOW YAH BROUGHT REBEKAH

Before He brought her, He made me content without her.

I got to a place where I was settled in my heart about being alone. I told Yahshua straight out in prayer that I was going to live the rest of my life for Him either way. And I told Him that if He did have someone for me, she had to be in the same place in her faith that I was. No compromise on that. I had already lived what happens when you are unequally yoked and call it love. *(2 Corinthians 6:14)*

About a week after that prayer, Rebekah messaged me.

We had a pile of friends in common, all of them connected to the faith. We started talking, and a week later we met in person on May 11, 2023. That day we happened to drive past a street sign that said TRUELOVE.

We knew. On September 29, 2023, we were married. *(Proverbs 18:22)*



May 11, 2023. The day we met.

THE GIRL WHO WAS PRAYING FOR A FATHER

Rebekah did not come alone.

Her daughter was eight years old when we met, and she had been praying for a father.

I need you to sit with that for a second. On one side of town there was a man who had been praying for years to be made into a good father, watching his own children get further away from him. On the other side there was an eight year old girl asking Yah for a dad.

He was answering both prayers at the same time, and neither one of us could see it.

She is my daughter. Not a replacement for the ones I am still waiting on, because children are not replaceable and I will never speak about them that way. But she is mine, and Yah gave her to me, and He gave me to her. *(Joel 2:25)*

WHERE WE ARE NOW

Yah did not stop refining us once He put us together. He kept right on removing anything that did not belong in our lives.

We cut out alcohol and unnecessary medicine so we could stay sober minded and keep every demonic door shut and locked. I have not touched alcohol in three years and have not touched marijuana in over a year. We practice forgiveness on purpose, because unforgiveness is one of the enemy's favorite entry

points. And we limit anything that can open spiritual doors: music, TV, games, worldly influences, and even certain people.

All of it protects the peace Yah gave us and keeps us walking in the freedom He intended.

WHAT I WANT YOU TO DO WITH THIS

Seek Yahshua with all your heart. Whatever your circumstances look like right now, seek Him. He says that when you search for Him with your whole heart, you will find Him. *(Jeremiah 29:13)*

He is there even when you are certain He is not. Especially then. *(Hebrews 13:5, Psalm 34:18)*

Do not give up, and do not hold onto unforgiveness. Forgive, and keep seeking Him, and He will work it all out for your good and for His glory. He works miracles in situations that have no way out. I am one of them. *(Romans 8:28)*

It takes struggle. It takes tribulation. That is how He refines us into the people He wants us to be. *(Isaiah 43:2)*

I prayed for years for Yah to make me a good father, a good husband, a set apart man. I could not see that He was already answering that prayer by letting me walk through the fire. And I could not see that while I was praying it, there was a little girl on the other side of town praying for the very thing He was making me into.

I came out refined. Purified. Shaped on the potter's wheel into a vessel He can actually use. *(Isaiah 64:8, 2 Timothy 2:21)*

If you are in the fire right now, you are not being abandoned. You are being made.

HalleluYah

Walk in truth. Walk in Light. Shalom.

SCRIPTURE REFERENCES

In the order they appear. WEB, divine name rendered YHWH, Elohim, and Adonai.

Ephesians 4:26-27

"Be angry, and don't sin." Don't let the sun go down on your wrath, neither give place to the devil.

Hebrews 12:15

Looking carefully lest there be any man who falls short of the grace of Elohim, lest any root of bitterness springing up trouble you, and many be defiled by it.

Matthew 18:34-35

His lord was angry, and delivered him to the tormentors until he should pay all that was due to him. So my heavenly Father will also do to you, if you don't each forgive your brother from your hearts for his misdeeds.

John 8:36

If therefore the Son makes you free, you will be free indeed.

2 Corinthians 5:17

Therefore if anyone is in Messiah, he is a new creation. The old things have passed away. Behold, all things have become new.

1 Corinthians 6:16

Or don't you know that he who is joined to a prostitute is one body? For, "The two," he says, "will become one flesh."

Matthew 27:12-14

When he was accused by the chief priests and elders, he answered nothing. Then Pilate said to him, "Don't you hear how many things they testify against you?" He gave him no answer, not even one word, so that the governor marveled greatly.

1 Peter 2:23

Who, when he was cursed, didn't curse back. When he suffered, didn't threaten, but committed himself to him who judges righteously.

Proverbs 4:23

Keep your heart with all diligence, for out of it is the wellspring of life.

Matthew 12:43-45

But the unclean spirit, when he is gone out of the man, passes through waterless places, seeking rest, and doesn't find it. Then he says, "I will return into my house from which I came;" and when he has come back, he finds it empty, swept, and put in order. Then he goes and takes with himself seven other spirits more evil than he is, and they enter in and dwell there. The last state of that man becomes worse than the first.

Isaiah 55:11

So is my word that goes out of my mouth: it will not return to me void, but it will accomplish that which I please, and it will prosper in the thing I sent it to do.

1 Peter 1:6-7

Wherein you greatly rejoice, though now for a little while, if need be, you have been grieved in various trials, that the proof of your faith, which is more precious than gold that perishes even though it is tested by fire, may be found to result in praise, glory, and honor.

Malachi 3:3

He will sit as a refiner and purifier of silver, and he will purify the sons of Levi, and refine them as gold and silver.

Proverbs 22:6

Train up a child in the way he should go, and when he is old he will not depart from it.

2 Corinthians 6:14

Don't be unequally yoked with unbelievers, for what fellowship do righteousness and iniquity have? Or what fellowship has light with darkness?

Proverbs 18:22

Whoever finds a wife finds a good thing, and obtains favor of YHWH.

Joel 2:25

I will restore to you the years that the swarming locust has eaten, the great locust, the grasshopper, and the caterpillar, my great army which I sent among you.

Jeremiah 29:13

You shall seek me, and find me, when you search for me with all your heart.

Hebrews 13:5

For he has said, "I will in no way leave you, neither will I in any way forsake you."

Psalm 34:18

YHWH is near to those who have a broken heart, and saves those who have a crushed spirit.

Romans 8:28

We know that all things work together for good for those who love Elohim, for those who are called according to his purpose.

Isaiah 43:2

When you pass through the waters, I will be with you, and through the rivers, they will not overflow you. When you walk through the fire, you will not be burned, and flame will not scorch you.

Isaiah 64:8

But now, YHWH, you are our Father. We are the clay and you our potter. We all are the work of your hand.

2 Timothy 2:21

If anyone therefore purges himself from these, he will be a vessel for honor, sanctified, and suitable for the master's use, prepared for every good work.

REFERENCE INDEX

UNFORGIVENESS

Matthew 18:34-35; Mark 11:25; 2 Corinthians 2:10-11

BITTERNESS

Ephesians 4:26-27; Hebrews 12:15; Proverbs 4:23

DELIVERANCE

Luke 4:18; John 8:36; 2 Corinthians 5:17

UNCLEAN SPIRITS

Matthew 12:43-45; Mark 5:12-13

SOUL TIES

Genesis 2:24; 1 Corinthians 6:16

SILENCE UNDER ACCUSATION

Matthew 27:12-14; 1 Peter 2:23; Isaiah 53:7

BOUNDARIES

Proverbs 22:24-25; 1 Corinthians 15:33; 2 Corinthians 6:14

REFINING

1 Peter 1:6-7; Malachi 3:3; Zechariah 13:9; Romans 5:3-5

TRIALS

James 1:2-4; Isaiah 43:2

THE POTTER

Isaiah 64:8; Jeremiah 18:4-6; 2 Timothy 2:21

SEEKING YHWH

Jeremiah 29:13; Hebrews 13:5; Psalm 34:18

RESTORATION

Joel 2:25; Romans 8:28

MARRIAGE

Proverbs 18:22

CHILDREN

Proverbs 22:6; Isaiah 55:11

Walk in truth. Walk in Light. Shalom.